

BHOODAN AS SEEN BY THE WEST

a
SARVODAYA PUBLICATION

PUBLISHER'S NOTE

The Bhoodan Yagna of Acharya Vinoba began in Hyderabad six years ago and it has now reached the climax of Gramdan or the gift of the whole village. It has widely attracted the world's attention. Many journalists and eminent persons of the West have wondered at the possibility of the success of this phenomenal movement of conquest of land for the landless and the establishment of Village Republics through love and non-violence. They have written in the leading journals of the world or talked on the radio about their reactions to this 'one man's revolution' in Free India. These have been published in our monthly magazine "Sarvodaya" from time to time. This is a revised and enlarged edition of the previous collection from the "Sarvodaya" and we are again greatly indebted to the contributors and journals from which they are taken. We have also included in this the recent interesting interview in January last of Mrs. Chester Bowles with Vinobaji as it refers to Gramdan, the latest phase of the movement.

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Sarvodaya Prachuralayam
(Akhila Bharat Sarva Seva Sangh)

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BHOODAN AS SEEN BY THE WEST

**—An appraisal of the Land-gift mission by
some Western Seekers—**

Sarvodaya Prachuralayam

(AKHILA BHARAT SARVA SEVA SANGH)

TANJORE

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Vinoba's Loot With Love

ROBERT TRUMBULL

TRUDGING across this bleak land (in Bihar) last week, surrounded by adoring crowds wherever he went, was a gentle, half-deaf little wisp of a man, dressed in the garb of poverty—a homespun *dhoti* and cheap brown canvas sneakers but lighted by a flame of authority that has made him one of India's most notable spiritual leaders. His name is Vinoba Bhave (pronounced *bah vay*). He has no place in the government or any other secular organization; he is what Hindus call an *Acharya* (preceptor). Only a land with holy cities, sacred rivers and thin margins between want and plenty could have produced frail (5' 4", 86 lbs.), ascetic Vinoba Bhave. In two years he has become such a power in India that only Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru is better known to the Indian masses.

Vinoba, as he is known to millions, was a trusted and faithful disciple of the late Mahatma Gandhi. He even looks somewhat like Gandhi, except for a grey beard and frowsy dark hair. He has the same emaciated body, wears the same sort of bifocal glasses, speaks in the same calm, soft voice, with kindly humor. One of the most learned men in India, he has studied Sanskrit, Persian, Urdu, Hindi, Marathi, Gujarathi, Bengali, Telugu, Kanarese, Malayalam and English, and this array of languages serves him well on his travels through polyglot India. It is not for his learning, however, that India's millions have given their hearts to Vinoba Bhave. They have done that because he, like their beloved *Bapu* (as they call Gandhi), has brought them a new hope.

It is no new doctrine that Vinoba preaches. It only seems so, because the times have given it new urgency. Walking from one to another of India's 700,000 villages, he asks those who have land to share it with those who have none. Without using the words of the gentle Evangelist who preceded him by two thousand years, he tells his audiences that it is more blessed to give than to receive. To those who have land he says: "I have come to loot you with love. If you have four sons, consider me as the fifth, and accordingly give me my share." To impoverished tenants and landless laborers he says: "We are all members of a single human family."

The results of this simple approach to man's better nature have been astonishing. Bhave calls his campaign *Bhoomidan-yagna*, which means a sacrificial offering of land. Since he began his land distribution campaign two years ago, Vinoba has walked 6,500 miles on tireless feet, and has distributed more than a million acres of land to the poor. The largest single gift was 100,000 acres from a maharajah. The smallest was a *gantha* (one fortieth of an acre), donated by a Telingana peasant who owned only one acre himself.

Not all of the gifts are prompted by charitable impulse. Some wealthy landowners support Vinoba Bhave and make donations because they hope his gentle usurpation will appeal to the mystic strain in all good Hindus more than the violence of Communism. Bhave has proved that, under certain circumstances, Indians do prefer his way, that *Bhoomidan-yagna* is more effective in ending unrest than jailing thousands of Reds.

At one place he said: "Whatever village I go to, people tell me about the atrocities of the Communists. I pray to God to let the feeling of love for Communists also reside in

my heart. Although the Communists commit acts of violence, still, how can we hate them? I wish every one to realize God. I always pray to Him that He should kindle good faith in the heart of every man." In another village, held in a vise of terror, he spoke directly to the Communists: "Do you really believe in your ideology? If so, why not come in the daytime instead of by night? If you want to loot the people, loot as I do, with sincerity and affection."

Every party in India approves of Bhave's movement, including Nehru's Congress Party and Socialists—every party, that is, except the Communists. Even the Communists do not denounce the man or his goal, only his method (which they profess to scorn as inadequate and unworkable, despite the fact that it works). For 30 years the Congress Party has talked land reform, studied schemes, but has accomplished little. After independence, Nehru turned over land legislation to the state governments, where it has been obstructed by landowner interests. Of India's 357 million people, in a land where plague, pests, drought, floods, debt and ignorance conspire to perpetuate abject poverty, Bhave is one man who is doing something tangible about redistributing the land. To the Western eye, there are visible shortcomings in Vinoba's *Bhoomidan-yagna*. It has not increased the number of acres or the quantity of crops, and therefore—his critics say—provides no conclusive answer to India's immense agricultural problem. Although more than 70% of India's people work the land for a living, the nation must import food or starve. Yet *Bhoomidan-yagna* has given pride of ownership to hundreds of thousands, and hope to millions more.

Vinoba Bhave is a sick man : he has duodenal ulcer and malaria. For food, he takes only two cups of milk daily, the second laced with honey. Yet somehow he finds the

energy to walk a steady ten to twenty miles a day. When he is on the road, he and his disciples get up in some sleeping village at 3 a.m. There is a patter of handclaps, a tinkling bell, the flash of a kerosene lantern, the shuffling of sandals in the dust, and the little group departs for the next village, singing hymns. When he is not on the road, Vinoba gets up an hour later and meditates for an hour. At 5, he has his first cup of milk, swishing each mouthful exactly eight times before swallowing.

Bhave's entourage numbers a dozen or more enthusiastic young Hindus, male and female, average age about 24, who stay three months to a year with him, so that the membership is constantly changing. Some disciples usually precede him to the next village, to announce his arrival from a sound tract and to see that everything is in order (including latrine-digging, if a big crowd is expected). The only permanent member of the group is Damodar Das, 38, who joined Gandhi at 18 and became Bhave's secretary after the Mahatma died. Damodar Das mails copies of Vinoba's speeches to the newspapers and keeps track of the land deeds, although each one is shrewdly inspected and initialled by Bhave personally.

Bhave's *ashram* (retreat) is at Puanar in Madhya Pradesh, about six miles from Gandhi's former *ashram* at Wardha. The main bungalow at Puanar, donated by Gandhi's old benefactor, the late Millionaire Jamnalal Bajaj, seemed so luxurious to the ascetic Bhave that he was tempted to refuse it. Finally he accepted, but stripped the bungalow to its bare walls. Like Gandhi before him, Bhave is an expert spinner and weaver. Unless it is raining, he sleeps outdoors every night, whether on the road or at Puanar.

Vinoba Bhave was born 57 years ago to a Brahman (high caste) family in Gangoda, a village in western India. His given name was Vinayak, but Gandhi changed it to Vinoba in later years, and the disciple accepted it as his name. At ten the boy began his career of holy name: he made a resolution of lifelong celibacy, gave up sweets and started going barefoot. Gandhi, who in young manhood was a lawyer and a comfortably married man, admired Vinoba's untarnished virginity. The Mahatma frequently said that his only regret in life was that he had known the delights of sex.

At 20, Bhave was shipped off to study at Bombay, but went instead to Bengal. Apparently (he is reticent about his early life) he joined the nationalist movement in Bengal, eating at public kitchens. He studied Sanskrit at Benares, and became deeply immersed in Hindu theology. He first saw Gandhi in 1916. Being too shy to approach the Mahatma, Bhave wrote a letter instead, and Gandhi invited him to join the *ashram* at Sabarmati. When Gandhi learned that his new follower had not written to his family for several years, he sat down himself and wrote to Bhave's father: "Your Vinoba is with me. His spiritual attainments are such as I myself attained only after a long struggle."

Bhave was restless at Sabarmati, however, and went away to study more Sanskrit, telling Gandhi that if he did not find peace of soul he would be back in a year. Over the ensuing months, the others in the *ashram* forgot his promise, but one morning at prayers, the Mahatma said that this was the day Vinoba had promised to return. Vinoba was back before nightfall.

In 1932 Bhave suffered his first arrest for taking part in Gandhi's civil-disobedience movement. Thereafter he

spent several more terms in British jail, serving a total of about two years. After India won her nationhood, through the bloody communal riots between Hindus and Muslims and through Gandhi's death, Bhave remained in obscurity, except for occasional newspaper articles carrying his strictures against money. To Bhave, money "tells lies and is like a loafing tramp." For a medium of exchange he favoured scrip, showing the number of hours a person had worked to earn it.

Two years ago he went to the state of Hyderabad to attend a meeting of Gandhi's old disciples. The Communists were terrorizing Hyderabad, especially the Telingana district, and Bhave was appalled by what he found there.

In the 10,000 square miles of Telingana, 8,000,000 peasants had long suffered the worst land tyranny in India. They were virtual serfs, without hope of getting land of their own. Communist guerrillas moved in to correct this—in their own way. They killed or put to flight scores of landowners, distributed the land, seized whole villages and set up their own schools. In battles between guerrillas and state constables backed by government troops, 3,000 people were killed and 35,000 Reds jailed. Both landowners and farmers were caught in the murderous crossfire.

Bhave wandered into areas from which the police had warned him to stay away, but he was unharmed. At first he preached *ahimsa* (Gandhi's old non-violence), but he soon saw that this was not enough. "I confess," he said, "that the incendiary and murderous activities did not unnerve me, because I know that the birth of a new culture has always been accompanied in the past by blood baths. What is needed is not to get panicky, but to keep our heads cool and find a peaceful means of resolving the conflict. The police are not expected

to think out and institute reforms. To clear a jungle of tigers, their employment would be useful. But here we have to deal with human beings, however mistaken and misguided. When a new idea is born, new repression cannot combat it."

Then Vinoba Bhave thought of asking land-owners to give land to the landless, saying (or at least politely implying) that if they did not, the Communists or the Government might take it away. Thus *Bhoomidan-yagna* was born, in bloody Telingana. Even the Nizam of Hyderabad, reputed one of the richest and most miserly men in the world, gave some land, though neither the Nizam nor Bhave would say how much (the merit acquired by giving is lost by boasting of it). Some 35,000 acres were collected and reassigned to the most destitute. Gradually the revolt and the terror died down.

Prime Minister Nehru's government was delighted. Nehru too is Gandhi's heir—but a modern, half Westernized one. Gandhi had a political core which Bhave ignores and Nehru has inherited. Nehru, moreover, believed in industrialization and irrigation and vast schemes; Bhave believes in self-denial and spinning wheels. After Bhave's triumph in Telingana, Nehru wanted him to come to New Delhi and discuss *Bhoomidan-yagna* with the National Planning Commission, and offered to send a plane down to fly Vinoba back. Vinoba said: "I will come, but in my own time, and as always." He walked with members of his *ashram*. New Delhi was 795 miles away.

That slow plodding to the capital, which took two months, was a triumphant journey. At nearly every town and village Bhave found arbours of palms and mango leaves erected for him to walk through. Underfed, ragged villagers

crowded around to touch the holy man's feet, and to bathe them when he would stop for a rest. Municipal dignitaries garlanded him with flowers, which the little ascetic passed back to the crowd. At each departure, the elders walked with him a mile toward the next village. And at every stop, he held a prayer meeting and carried on with *Bhoomidan-yagna*.

At New Delhi, he stayed in a bamboo hut near the concrete ghat in which Gandhi's body was cremated. Nehru called twice, in the midst of a busy election campaign. Dr. Rajendra Prasad, the President of India, came and told Bhave to take as much as he wanted of Prasad's land holding in Bihar. Members of the Planning Commission came and stayed for hours. Even a delegation of Communists, headed by Party Boss Ajoy Ghosh, paid a courteous visit. After eleven days, Bhave left New Delhi and has not been back to the capital since. He dislikes cities.

Three months ago, while walking through Bihar, Vinoba Bhave was seized with acute malaria. His temperature rose above 103, but he kept on walking as long as he could, then continued by bullock cart. In Chandil, a small village, he collapsed and was put to bed, but he refused all medication. "God", he said, "either wants to free me or desires to purify this body for employing it again in His work." He also refused to be taken to a hospital in Patna, the state capital. Said he: "Do not people also die in Patna?"

Crowds gathered around the house where the holy man lay ill. Half a dozen state and national government officials sent doctors to care for him. Dr. Prasad and others pleaded with him to take the drugs they prescribed.

Finally, on being assured that the medicines contained no animal matter, Bhave consented. He improved almost

immediately. During his convalescence, Nehru and Prasad flew down for a visit. And his disciples carried on with *Bhoomidan-yagna*, collecting 33,000 acres of land. When Bhavé took to the road again, the donations came in so fast that the *ashram's* book-keeping system was almost snowed under. Last week, after 110 miles of dusty tramping in Bihar, he had picked up another 365,000 acres.

Nowadays Vinoba Bhavé reads only three books. Euclid's *Elements*, Aesop's *Fables* and the *Bhagavad Gita*: For him as for Gandhi, the *Bhagavad Gita* is the supreme book of human guidance. This great Sanskrit poem, imbedded in a larger work called the *Mahabharata*, is later than the Vedas and the Upanishads, and fills a role in the Hindu holy books something like that of the New Testament in the Bible. During one of his jail terms, Vinoba lectured every Sunday on the *Gita*. He translated it into Marathi* verse, and this work sold about a quarter of a million copies.

The *Gita* prescribes three paths for the soul's union with God: *Karma-yoga* the way of action, *Jnana-yoga*, the way of knowledge, and *Bhakti-yoga*, the way of love. The poem is set in the frame of bloody battle, a great battle on the plain of Kurukshetra. The hero, Arjuna, is downcast because he must fight against men who, he suspects, are his brothers, even though they are foes, and the god Krishna gives Arjuna advice. Krishna persuades Arjuna that it is permissible to fight, indeed, that he must fight, so long as the struggle serves no selfish ends. Although most Indian scholars believe that the poem refers to a real battle, Gandhi was so deeply committed to non-violence that he convinced himself that the battle of Kurukshetra was an allegory, that it portrayed the conflict of good and evil in the human heart.

* A Sanskrit language spoken in Western India.

Bhave practises *Karma-yoga*, the way to God through action in the world. "You must perform every action sacramentally, and be free from all attachment to results." It is not to be undertaken without first mastering the other yogas, learning control of the body, the breathing and the mind ; learning concentration through love and devotion by prayer ; gaining knowledge by meditation.

Vinoba Bhave has read and admired the scriptures of other religions, and he knows that the way of love was discovered long ago in many places outside the mountain-walled subcontinent of India. Yet in this racked century, the way of love seems, as *Bhoomidan-yagna* shows, always new.

"My object", says Vinoba Bhave, "is to transform the whole of society. Fire merely burns; it does not worry whether anyone puts a pot on it, fills it with water and puts rice in it to make a meal. Fire burns and does its duty. It is for others to do theirs."

"The people are going to solve their problems, not I. I am simply creating an atmosphere. The beginning is always small, but when the atmosphere spreads, somebody will ask—and somebody will give."

"Reader's Digest" June 1952.

The Greatest Bloodless Revolution

J. M. PRENTICE

“Acharya Vinoba Bhave and land gift movement” formed the principal theme of a special radio broadcast from Sydney by Mr. J. M. Prentice, renowned Australian radio commentator on Sunday (July 26) under the ‘International Portrait of the Week’ series.

In this broadcast Acharya Bhave was introduced as “the outstanding Indian reformer, who is actuated only by a spirit of love, a trusted and beloved disciple of the late Mahatma Gandhi, whom he resembles and in whose footsteps he walks, a man who is a great spiritual leader in the world where such are sadly lacking.”

Comparing Acharya Vinoba with Gandhiji, Mr. Prentice observed : “Physical attributes aside, there is one thing more which they possess in common—that inward flame of spiritual authority which glows from within, that light which is not of this world, which lifts Vinoba Bhave to the high position of being one of India’s most notable spiritual leaders. How much this is so may be gauged by the fact that this frail leaf of a man has risen in the last two years to a position of power in India that makes him second only to Pandit Nehru himself in the devotion and recognition of the Indian masses.”

Mr. Prentice further observed : “The Indian masses esteem him not for his learning but because he cherishes them in his heart and works for them. It is for that they have given him adoration, a love hardly equalled for 20

centuries. The keynote of all that he has accomplished is his belief that those who have should give to those who have not. His land gift movement has brought home a new vision to millions more. It is the application of all that Mr. Gandhi visualised; it brings to life a new sweetness and a new hope. It is the application of the law of life and if it spreads, it amounts to the greatest bloodless revolution the world has ever known. It could well be that in centuries to come Acharya Bhave would be looked back to as an Avatara (incarnation) of God himself."

Giving chronological details of Vinoba's political career, Mr. Prentice ended the broadcast thus, "Bhave knows and respects the sacred scriptures of other faiths, but his heart is filled with the teachings of his own faith, deeply-felt faith, that has prompted him to undertake a course of action which could change the whole face of the world. It seems certain that Mahatma Gandhi and Vinoba Bhave will walk hand in hand down centuries."



A Bloodless Revolution

Miss PAT. McMAHON

I**N 1951, I left the University of Michigan discouraged and alarmed by world events. As a student of social psychology, I was determined to find why India, the most poverty-stricken country, could find strength for a bloodless revolution, a detached foreign policy and an active self-improvement programme while most 'have-not' countries were still oppressed and involved in violent dissension.**

After arriving in India in order to find my education through practical experience, I have lived in institutions, worked with students building a village road, with a teacher and primary pupils constructing a mud school, and lastly and most important, travelled over 2,000 miles with Vinoba Bhave's land collection movement, going on foot through villages, jungles, cities, centres of ancient culture; living in temples, schools and homes.

From these efforts has come the knowledge of a more advanced way of life, the simplicity of the old village culture where people welcome strangers as they welcome their children, the selfless idealism of the villager giving land to the poor, the loving attention of the family for its young. Of course, unpleasant knowledge has come as well of purdah, bigoted people who consider work undignified, landlords treated as Gods, Indians turned against their countrymen adopting the values of the British.

But once a while some moving experience newly reminds me with a shock that there is a force stirring in this country that may jolt the world. A few days ago, a thin man in yellowed, once white clothes, his skin and bones showing

through the tears, bowed before Vinoba and presented all the land to be given to the poor. When the poor can give to the poorer, leaving themselves nothing but their strength to do other work, what greater motivation and trust are necessary?

In this age of wary scepticism, we find the new hope that in days of facing great social problems we shall stand about like men in a burning house, each unwilling to burn himself putting out the fire that is about to consume all. In India one man assumed the responsibility for 'putting out the fire'. To solve the problems facing India children unclothed, unfed, villagers digging little pits in dry river beds to find clean water, walking a mile to bring water from slimy green pools, men without land and without work, Vinoba Bhave has taken drastic steps which leave no doubt about his sincerity.

He has left his home forever to walk until land is distributed to the poor. He will take land, wealth, or labour donations from the poor as well as the rich. If he does not receive the first time, he or his workers will go again and again. Every individual has a right to those things that are necessary to his survival. Eating is as necessary as breathing and drinking; water, air and sunlight are free, why not land? And how can the rich refuse, when the poor give?

He accepts any workers, of any background or beliefs. He asks them to consider themselves first as human beings. Members of all India's parties have come to him, Hindus, Muslims, Christians, Buddhists. Many have told him that these people are working in this movement to gain prestige. His reply was "Let them come. There is no harm in prestige from good work. Need I go and ask them?"

It has been my luck to observe one of the most successful attempts in applied social psychology of the age. Vinoba Bhave has not only managed to get dissenting parties to co-operate towards the same goal and settled innumerable disputes, but now that the movement has gained momentum, in less than three weeks he has gathered 3,70,000 acres of land. Approximately 70,000 peasants living near starvation, shall be able to grow their own food, wells are being dug, bullocks and labour have been given for land reclamation.

As we tramp along the road, we are met by large arches of mango leaves, handed garlands deafened by blasts of long pipe-stemmed horns, peacock-tailed drums, conch shells, singing and shouting. Between villages we meet people on their way to market, peasants in the field, pilgrims on their way to religious festivals. After a morning walk of 10 or 15 miles, we stop in a village, city or town, and local people give us our breakfast and go travelling from village to village, or house to house, bringing forms describing the land given. Crowds of people stand in the windows, doors watching us as we work. In the evening there are meetings of a few hundreds or a hundred thousands and the names of the donors or villagers will be read.

Leaving this movement will be jumping from a running train. Every day brings a new idea, a new experience. A movement that was once only one man's determined to undertake his nation's problems, though he might accomplish little and it should take until the day of his death, is now a movement of the nation, with workers in every province giving a year of their time to speed up his programme. It has been a wonderful inspiration for me and for those who are discontented and disillusioned with 'magic' formulas; it stands a bright, new challenge.

*(The writer is an American lady, who joined
Vinobaji's Yatra party in Sept. 1952)*

A Saint Walks in India

FRANK HORVAT

IN 1951, armed Indian Communists, taking advantage of troubles in Hyderabad, killed landlords in the district of Telengana and distributed their property among the landless peasants. Three thousand people were killed and 35,000 jailed, before Government troops restored order.

That might have been the spark to kindle a nation-wide revolution for land reform by violence. As it turned out, it touched off quite a different sort of revolution—a one-man crusade based on goodwill and non-violence which is still sweeping India like fire.

Indeed, that is how the man who started it describes himself. "I am like the fire," declares Vinoba Bhave. "The function of fire is to burn. It does not worry if man uses it for good or evil—or not at all. My preaching creates a proper atmosphere for non-violent solution of economic problems. The people will solve the problems—not I. It is up to them to get the best out of the atmosphere I create."

In less than three years, the 'atmosphere' has resulted in India's notoriously tenacious landlords parting with enough land to settle two and a half million of the nation's 50 million landless peasants—voluntarily. Neither the Communists by violence, nor the Government by legislation, could have achieved anything like it.

Although its consequences may be very complicated, the secret of this staggering success is simple. Vinoba's appeal is spiritual, not political; aimed direct at the heart, not the head. This formidable scholar (besides English,

Arabic and Persian, he speaks eight of India's principal regional languages) talks in words that the most child-like can understand. "One-sixth of India's people are landless. If one of you has five sons and a sixth is born to him, he will divide his property into six parts instead of five. I am asking for one-sixth of India's soil on behalf of the landless. Consider me as your sixth son." His other main asset is that he is in everyday touch with the real heart of India—that overwhelming majority of her 350 millions 'who live in villages. Since he went to Hyderabad in 1951 to preach non-violence, he has walked nearly 10,000 miles (Land's End to John 'o' Groats is 850), avoiding towns and politicians, but constantly able to check at first hand the results of his experiment. Since September, 1952, Vinoba has concentrated on the North-Eastern Province of Bihar, which has three million landless peasants out of a population of 40 million. Here he aims to collect enough for all before the end of 1954, in a pilot project for his all-Indian goal of 50 million acres before the end of 1957.

Long before he started his land reform crusade, Vinoba was a national figure. His fame rested on the known facts of his personal holiness—a dedicated ascetic life since the age of ten, total celibacy and 40 years' practice of the discipline of Yoga. He became a follower of Gandhi in 1916 and though always identified with the spiritual side of the Nationalist movement, he was several times jailed as a political prisoner during the non-violence campaigns. His deliberate refusal to be tied by official connections (even when invited by Nehru) or to identify himself with political factions (although the right wing socialists dedicate their party's whole activity to supporting his crusade) has increased his authority and put him in a position above parties perhaps unequalled even by Gandhi's. His portrait

hangs in millions of huts, alongside the household gods—the Lord Krishna, the flute-playing god, Ganesh, the elephant-headed deity, and Hanuman. To the Indian peasant, he is ‘*babaji*’ (little grandfather), just as Gandhi was ‘*Bapu*’ (father).

Vinoba’s day begins at 3 a.m. with prayers and song with his closest disciples. At 4-30 he takes the road, lighted by a kerosene lamp until sunrise. Warned by disciples who have preceded him, of his coming, villagers go out to meet him with flowers, build triumphal arches and shout “*Santa Vinoba ki jai*” (Long live Vinoba, the saint).

Since he nearly died of malaria a year ago, he averages only ten, instead of 20 miles a day. Neither thunder, rain, mud nor wind deter him. He refuses an umbrella because “the rain is sent by God,” preferring to run to keep warm—often flanked by barefooted village girls or fat local politicians breathlessly trying to gain popularity by keeping pace with the cavalcade. On arrival he has one daily meal—milk or curd, fruit juice or raw vegetables. He is deafish and suffers from stomach ulcer, but after an hour’s rest he receives farmers and landlords, reads or dictates letters. Between two and four in the afternoon he spins—a symbolic Gandhian ritual. After more prayers, he speaks to assembled villagers, always trying to add something new to his repetition of his appeal for land to distribute. To his regular retinue of five, half a dozen temporary followers travel with him to get experience and inspiration before returning to collect land for his movement in their own home areas. The Government passed special legislation to simplify the transfer of land under his scheme by a witnessed signature or thumb-print on a prepared form. Landless villagers put in their claims before these meetings and, when donations do not meet demands, they are invited to

decide among themselves whose need is greatest. If they disagree the village elders are called upon and, if they too fail, lottery is held. In any case, receivers of land are pledged not to alienate it for ten years. To meet the objection that land given is often of poor quality and that its new owners have nothing to till it with, Vinoba has launched a subsidiary campaign for gifts of revenue over a number of years to provide bullocks, ploughs and seed for the new land-owners.

In the cold light of Western economics, Vinoba's crusade is full of pitfalls and anxious question marks. Like Gandhi, who never lived to practise as an administrator what he had preached as an agitator, he wants to save the Indian village from Western materialism. He would transfer virtually all powers to the village assembly, so that necessary reforms would come about *not* by legislation from Delhi, but from inside the village itself. In this way reforms would happen only when local conditions, based on the full understanding and consent of all the villagers, became ripe. A village assembly, for example, should have the right to prohibit imports of industrially produced food and mill cloth from the cities, where this would upset the pattern of village life or cause unemployment.

Since India chose to become a secular, progressive Republic, the conflict between Vinoba's teachings and Nehru's development programme is all too obvious.

Politically, Vinoba's critics ask whether simple peasants will not confuse his noble message with Communist invitations to grab land by violence. But no one dares assail—openly at least—the frail little man who probably represents today the biggest bloc of votes throughout the length and breadth of the country. Since Vinoba's triumph in Telengana,

the Communists are bitterly aware that he is their deadliest rival for the possession of the souls of those millions of under-privileged Indians whom Marxist theory had always promised them as easy recruits. In one village terrorised by Communists, he challenged them directly: "Do you really believe in your ideology? If so, why not come in the day-time instead of by night? If you want to loot the people—loot as I do, with sincerity and affection."

Since he began his campaign, India's President has told him to take what he wanted from his Bihar estates; that close fisted Moslem potentate, the Nizam of Hyderabad, has handed over an undisclosed amount of land; a single Rajah has given 350,000 acres and countless tiny holders have sacrificed parcels of their minute but treasured plots.

Vinoba Bhave is quite aware of the conflicts and problems he is creating—and quite undeterred. He believes that spiritual discipline, religious studies, prayer and meditation have qualified him to practise Karma-Yoga—the way of God through action. "You must perform every action sacramentally, and be free from all attachments to results."

Because of his undoubted integrity and terrifying single-mindedness, Vinoba's fire will continue to burn. To the people and their politicians he leaves the responsibility of turning the blaze into one of the world's greatest social and economic reformations, or letting it smoulder into a barren conflict between traditional Indian spiritual values and the Western tide of material progress.

[Picture Post (England) 16-1-1954]

Vinoba Bhaye The Saint

TAYA ZINKIN

AT dawn I take the train which snails its way towards Bhave, who is 80 miles distant. It stops eventually at a crossing; then, an ekka—a horse cart hanging from two wheels. Our bones are thoroughly ground together as we hop over ruts, drive into river-beds, cut across paddy fields. We arrive in time for lunch.

Bhave is not visible, he works. Gandhi's grand-daughter, Sumitra greets us—energetic, cheerful, a chic tomboy, amusing like her grandfather, vital like her grandmother, not weighted down by her illustrious heritage.

At 6 p.m. Bhave comes out for the prayer meeting. Never before in my experience of India had a meeting been silent. There is pindrop silence in the small courtyard where perhaps two hundred villagers squat. Babies do not whine, dogs have forgotten to bark. One can hear the sunset.

After prayers Bhave speaks gently: "Violence is bad, love is good. If you tell me you cannot give land because you already have seven sons and only a small holding, I will answer: I am your eighth son, I have come to take my rightful share."

Smallpox-pitted faces intent under wet towels and bulky turbans. A petrol lamp. The spreading shadows. A bunch of stars shoot by, Bhave has his cupful of curds, talks with Sumitra, goes to sleep.

Meanwhile, as if by magic 3,200 acres of land have been given to him by fourteen donors. We drag our aching bones

to our sleeping place; two men discuss. "What of your Bhoodan? All men are not equal: this is against nature," the sub-inspector of police, handsome swashbuckler with a flared moustache, asks.

Gopi Sen replies: "We must try. Bhoodan is what we make it; I am only a peasant, but Baba knows."

The moon rises over the hilltops, dusting the scorched earth with glitter: the guard and the disciple argue as if they are in Galilee.

The next day began at 3 a.m. We have to walk nine miles before sunrise. Bhav in front, slimmer, older, in the dangling light of the petrol lamp, hardly touches the earth in a race with his numbered days. "Time is on my side, therefore I cannot lose." The grey dust of Bihar sticks to his brown ankles as if the earth itself moved with him. Sixteen to twenty miles is his average, but he is unwell, so we only go nine miles.

After a five miles' race across country I give in. I lie on the edge of a well, watching ants creep, listening to the water trickle. When a rattle-trap jeep comes to pick me up I feel sorry. There had been so much peace everywhere, within and without. Peace which must have emanated from Bhav, so complete that nothing matters but the knowledge that it exists.

It is not that the world can go without the intellectuals. In fact, many intellectuals have been the sole cause for many an advancement in our activities in life. But what constitutes vice is their attitude towards life. Gandhiji has recorded that vices are more prevalent among them than among those who live from hand to mouth.

My mind stands before me, bared of its vulgarities, motives, make-believes, stripped naked by truth. Bhave acts as a catalyst.

That evening a landlord bared his conscience in front of Bhave's bed: "I am a poor man, I have already given 250 acres of land, I have many sons and they have many children, how can I give more? I would like to give, but I must think of them. What must I do?"

Bhave was asleep—a small clump of brown on a white sheet, hardly bigger than my small son. A catalyst, refusing himself, yet the cause. The Chief Minister of Bombay once said that he had experienced 'absolute peace and total absence of desire' in the presence of a very holy man: So it is in Bhave's.

Since Bhave was beaten up by priests for taking untouchables into a temple he is slightly deaf and questions must be written. Of my seventeen questions only one matters. "Why is it that I have no desire to speak with you, or stay with you, yet that I feel at peace and have no curiosity left. Does it make sense?"

This is his answer: "Talking is the least part of things. We feel. We love. We meditate. Talking should be used, to fraternise. Your question is not senseless. Silence is better than speech. It works wonders."

The third day I hovered around him for hours through a meeting of workers where a landlord who had already given 2,000 acres last year, announced that he would give another 2,000 and keep only 30 acres for himself and his family; through a public meeting where he thundered: "God will ask you: did Baba come to your village? Did

he tell you to give freedom to your wives? Have you done so? I came twenty months ago and your women are still in gaol" (there is strict purdah in parts of Bihar).

Then through the announcement that he had received 4,820 acres—excluding the 2,000 of the landlord—from 37 donors; through his evening meal; and all along he refused himself to me. He does not get involved with individuals. As he told the prayer meeting, "We must all solve our problems ourselves."

The fourth day the heat is unbearable. After lunch Santa wept softly, I swallowed a bottle of salt tablets, Vishnu could not type, and Sumitra cried in her sleep. My torch fell out of my pocket, burning. I thought it was a short-circuit: it was the heat concentrated in the metal casing. Bhabe seemed beyond the world. He dictated to Tia the whole afternoon, yet this morning he had run for nine miles and ended by crossing a river waist deep in water while we followed in canoe.

The last mile to the village he was far ahead of us, followed by small children flying home-made flags and singing songs: formidable crusaders of love, an old man and children, getting land for the poor.

Could Bhabe be effective outside India? The answer is, Yes; His being a scholar, dark-skinned, Gandhian, is all irrelevant. Bhabe is a saint and saints are universal.

(Singapore Standard 6-8-1954)

Ten Days with Vinobaji

Miss Lee Kleiss

THIS may sound as strange as any science, fiction story, and therefore I would like to share it with you. Imagine yourself on an Indian train which resembles a streetcar with its wooden seats and open windows. We are headed for Pusa Road Station in the State of Bihar. At present this whole area has been badly affected by the floods. It almost seems as if the train proceeds across a lake. Only trees and the railway ramp are showing above the water. The train travels more and more slowly. Out of curiosity we opened the door to look out. The bridge had given way under the pressure of the flood waters. We are heading for a new emergency bridge. The engineer, to his neck in water watches anxiously as our engine advances. The bridge holds, we are the first to cross. What a cheer from the work crew!

Somehow, this seemed a fitting entrance into the territory in which Vinoba Bhave is walking. A journey into *No Man's Land*; for he believes that the land belongs to God, no one should possess it. We may use it as we use the rain that nourishes the soil, or as we use the air we breathe. We all have the need and the right to food, shelter, and clothing. In poverty-stricken India with its high percentage of unemployment this is a serious problem. Yet if every family possessed five acres of land, all the basic needs, food, shelter, and clothing would be solved. A peasant can grow his food, find mud, stone, or bamboo to build his little hut, and grow cotton which he can spin and weave himself. If he owns his own land, he will care for

it and nourish it so that it will give better and more produce. As a labourer he has no such concern for the soil.

Many articles, pamphlets, and books have been written about Vinoba Bhave, but come along with me now to meet him. I joined five girls from the social workers' training centre where I had been staying. At 7 A.M. we reached a little village where green arches of welcome have been constructed, and children and adults had already gathered. The children were practising songs and calls—"Mahathma Gandhijiki Jai! Sant Vinobajiki Jai!" "Who will be landless in our village?—No one will be, no one will be!" A jeep came through with a loudspeaker announcing Vinobaji's arrival in Hindi. The children lined up on one side, the adults on the other side of the road. After fifteen minutes we saw some twenty people approaching, Vinobaji leading by some inches. All were clothed in Indian style, in white home-spun cloth. The people cheered, and as the group passed us, quickly followed. I was caught in a swirl and a rush and could hardly get a good look until the afternoon prayer meeting.

Already at 3 P.M. people were assembled and squatting down on the ground, and by 4 P.M. some 25 thousand had gathered. One of the members of the group adjusted the microphone and sang a song about this revolutionary movement. Some one else sang. There were announcements, "Please be seated, Do not smoke during the meeting" etc., and the calls were taught to the audience. At 4.45 Vinobaji arrived, stood on the platform while someone started the call, "Who will be landless in our village?" with the audience crying, "No one will be, no one will be!" Then he sat for the half hour of prayer sung by the group. As his speeches are in Hindi, I could not follow. He speaks about

love—how we should love one another, help one another, and share one another's burdens. Everyone should earn his bread by his own effort, not by the labour of others. Everyone has the right to food, shelter and clothing. Just as God lets rain fall on the just and the unjust, and has given us air to breathe, so we should not deny anyone his basic needs of food, shelter and clothing. For this reason the landless peasant needs land. He asks, "Will you please give? Adopt me into your family and give me a share of land which I will give to the landless. As the average Indian family has five children, let me be the sixth and give me a sixth of your land."

During the speech, children rise and squirm, but there is silence. All try to listen. The two loudspeakers are certainly not enough. Children form half the audience, and what noise there is, comes from them. They are not prevented from coming and leaving during the meeting.

After the speech Vinobaji remains to autograph his discourses on the message of the Gita in Hindi. The Gita has often been called the Hindu equivalent of the Sermon on the Mount. In the meantime members of the group are circulating through the crowd the special papers to be filled by those who give land.

Back at his quarters, I asked for permission to walk along with the group for ten days. It was granted. Next morning I joined the morning prayers at 3-30 A.M. and we are off on the march by 4-15. It is still dark. One man goes ahead with a lamp, and another walks besides Vinobaji with a lamp. The rest of us follow behind. The villages we pass are still asleep. Daylight has broken when we reach a large village in which there is an enthusiastic

welcome. In the rush we are all but trampled. A friend in homespun sees me and tries to make a path for me. This is the East, and I could not help but wonder if there had not been similar occasions in Palestine. The heat, the dust, the rush of barefooted, scantily dressed villagers all add to the atmosphere.

Soon after our arrival at the day's destination, we are all served our breakfast, Indian style on banana leaves. We girls, some twenty from the training centre come along for one day, were given a little room. A rug was placed on the damp earth, and we entered. There was just barely enough space for all of us to lie down, but we were tired enough to sleep. Until the afternoon meeting time we slept, bathed and washed our clothes, ate lunch, talked and slept again. It was very hot. Others were not so privileged as they had to prepare for the meeting, attend to the day's mail, etc. Again a two-hour prayer and speech meeting attended by an enthusiastic crowd.

That night I slept crowded between the other girls. It was not safe to stretch, you might kick the person in the next layer, and to turn over was almost impossible. At any rate I could not fall down as I was already on the floor. Hot and sweaty, I was glad to hear the 3 A.M. rising bell. We attended prayers and were off on a good dirt road. Already before sunrise the exercise of walking made us sweat. (It would be ridiculous to call it perspiring!)

A woman stopped us on the road. The members of the party tried to put her off to one side, but Vinobaji wished to listen to her. She had been dispossessed. The landlord claimed the ground on which her house rested. She was out on the road in the rainy season with two children. Vinobaji sent a message with the villagers to bring the land-

lord to the afternoon meeting. Afterwards both tenant and landlord faced their itinerant judge. It took three hours to settle her and another woman's case. A third woman had come but the landlord had not appeared.

Early morning prayers and we are off. This time the road is not so pleasant. We are ferried across some water. It is still dark, so I cannot tell whether it is a river or just flood water. We wind our way along some field paths, but even though soon have to take off our shoes and take to the water. We reach our destination at 7-30 A.M. Our new quarters are completely surrounded by water. We had to wade through two feet of water for nearly half a mile to reach them. Usually the quarters are in the local schools and often the school boys or scouts guard the place to protect us from the over-curious villagers that usually swarm about us. Even if we are in a room, they manage to open the shutters and to peep in. On this little island the water protected us a little. As usual local hospitality prepares and donates the food to the group.

The next day we are forced to take to the railway tracks, everything else is under water. Of the three trains which pass us, only one passenger recognizes Vinobaji and greets him. It was a sign of the indifference of the world outside. I had to recall the enthusiastic welcome in Jerusalem and the quick forgetfulness.

In a similar manner the remainder of my ten days were passed. When we had not walked very far, and it was cool enough, we went in little parties to the landlords directly requesting land. Other days gifts were taken only during the meeting. These varied in size from two to twentyfive thousand in attendance. It is not the big landlords that Vinobaji approaches. He asks of all since, if enough little people give, the moral atmosphere will change. It is not a

material communistic revolution he wishes to create but a practical spiritual revolution. The final goal resembles very much a universal system of intensional communities similar to the early Christian communities; small village communities living together in the spirit of love like large families with no ownership of land and the needs of all being equally satisfied. The final goal would do away with all need of government, but such a goal is not immediately realizable, therefore Vinobaji believes a real democratic government to be necessary and good. But the mere possession of the vote hardly means democracy. Though the goal is that land should be used in common, at present the land donated is to be distributed to individual families.

Though the main request at present is for land, for the total revolution many gifts are possible. Firstly came Bhoodan—gift of land, then Sampatti Dan—gift of property ($\frac{1}{4}$ of one's income), Buddhi Dan—gift of professional skill and knowledge, Shrama Dan—gift of work, and lastly there has developed Jivan Dan or gift of life. I spoke with one young man who has been asked "Come, follow me." He could not, for he has a mother and a sister to provide for and a growing law practice. Again and again I am reminded of the similarity of Christ's preaching and healing tour on foot through Palestine. Some part of the message, such as the homespun clothes, may not be directly applicable for us in the West, and even if we cannot accept that he is Saint Vinoba, he still challenges us to become real Christians, for it is the same age-old message of love, non-violence, devotion, and service that he preaches as he walks from village to village not knowing where he will rest his head at night.

(The writer is an American lady dedicated to social service who came to India as a volunteer in the S. C. I.)

The Village that gave itself to God

Evelyn Reynolds

IN the United Provinces, even a famous village is difficult to find. For several hours, our jeep had been trundling along blurred paths through the treeless plain. Then a river obstructed. "We have arrived," said Karanbhai, relieved. Seeing nothing, we waded through the shallows, climbed the steep red cliff on the other shore—and there we were, thrust into a reception fit for Rama: the six hundred villagers had turned out to a man, and a riot of drums and cymbals and conches at our heels, we were swept towards a lavishly draped chariot with twenty pairs of bullocks to draw us along the last mile of our journey.

They were used to welcoming guests. Before our arrival, they had had other visitors, from as far afield as Delhi—social workers, journalists, even a diplomat—for having given all its lands to Vinoba Bhave, the village of Mongroth had made history. Or rather, it had re-emerged into history; for a hundred years ago it had been a town with a population of 20,000, but after some disaster in the Mutiny the town had faded out, leaving behind only a whitewashed fort, the residence of an old family of Zamindars, to gather around it the mud huts which had sprung up, irrepressibly, from the dead site.

Karanbhai, who was in charge of Vinoba's Bhoodan movement in the United Provinces, gave an account of recent developments to our party of observers. The Mongroth story had begun in the fort: for Diwan Sahib, the Zamindar, had been canvassing land reforms in the village even before Bhoodan came into existence, and when

Vinoba came to Mongroth in 1952, to ask for land for the poor in the name of God, the ground had been prepared. After two days and nights of deliberation, the villagers, headed by Diwan Sahib, offered up all their lands to the Saint, and slogans were painted on the walls of the huts: "All lands belong to God," (they ran in large, tumbling letters) and: "Long live Saint Vinoba." The offering was accepted, the villagers signed the Gift Deeds distributed to them and sent them on to Vinoba and his workers, who had meanwhile resumed their pilgrimage.

But it remained a symbolic gesture for many months and things continued as before. A social worker from Wardha came to stay for a while, but the villagers were suspicious of the reform schemes whereby he tried to make them redeem their pledge, and, not liking him, did nothing. In fact, they were beginning to have second thoughts: what might ultimately be demanded of them? How were they going to live, and find money for their daughters' dowries? Were they really all landless now, as the villagers from the neighbourhood maliciously suggested, not having themselves taken any generous risks? But while the men were arguing about the theory of the case, the women remained firm. "We have given our lands to a Saint," they said, "and we should certainly be punished if we revoked the gift."

And they prevailed. A year later, Karanbhai arrived at the village and, the tide of goodwill having mysteriously turned, things began to move. He had brought with him all the Gift Deeds offering to return them. When the offer was refused, he set the uneasy villagers to work as trustees of their own gift; presently, a Village Welfare Council was elected to decide, first of all, upon three alternatives of farming: collective, co-operative or individual. A compromise emerged. One-third of the villagers, including Diwan

Sahib, joined in a fully fledged collective—Parivar, the Family, it was called—and those who had been landless were absorbed in it.

The rest chose individual farming, and previous holdings were slightly modified, to introduce as much equality as the villagers would accept.

On the day after our arrival, I went out into the sesame fields to see the Family at work. Bindraban, one of the last night's cart drivers, came to meet me, smiling. He had no land before, and now he was well satisfied. Like all the other collective workers, he received no wages, but food and clothes were distributed as rations from the common pool. No work—no rations, of course, unless there was a good reason for being absent. The other day, one of the young men had stayed away. He had no shoes, he said, when questioned, and they provided him with a pair. When he still did not attend work the next morning, they stopped his rations : within a day, he was back.

But where Bindraban's worries ended, those of the Village Council, deliberating in the Diwan's courtyard began : they were only just finding out how many problems there were. They had decided to switch cultivation from sesame and other cash crops to food grains and to become self-sufficient ; but to do that they would need more water, and how were they going to find the 70,000 rupees for a tube well ? Then, there was soil erosion ; they had edged the steep gulleys at the back of the village with wooden plinths, linked by a fence of twigs until a hedge grew to hold the crumbling soil, but would it outlast the rains ? Village industries were to be revived ; they were making their own shoes now, sturdy things recalling a rhinoceros' muzzle—but how to work the handlooms so long discarded ?

And there were other difficulties. Even with Vinoba as landlord and the village community as trustee, some of the holdings were much better than others, and the individual farmers were better off than the Family. The Diwan, a Tolstoyan patriarch of splendid bearing, was much grieved at this persistence of inequality, and he had suggested to the villagers that they should now take another plunge and share all their possessions in true communist fashion. "But they don't seem to like the idea," he said, sadly. "No.", said Karanbhai, "we must not do too much at once. A little at a time." It was a gamble, and disconcerting rumours kept drifting in from the neighbouring villages. Nevertheless, Mongroth had earned its fame: it certainly was a most exceptional village.

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The March for Peace

Alfred Knaus

“DON'T go to India” said one of my friends, “I have seen Bombay. It is the gate-way to hell.” I went against his good advice and—have spent in India already one year more than intended.

A few months ago some Indian said: “Why do you insist on meeting Vinoba? He is a cold man and won't talk with you at all.” I went and two hours after my arrival in Gunupur I met the “cold man.” With a smiling face he took me by the shoulder and said: “O, our German friend.....you must tell me your whole story.” This was my first personal meeting with Vinoba but not my last one. It was just on his 61st birthday, September 11. I used the opportunity to deliver the birthday greetings of the German friends of the FOR and WRI. Many people had gathered there at Gunupur to celebrate this day. Among them was also Sri Jai Prakash Narain, the socialist leader who offered Jeevan Dan for Bhoodan. But as there was heavy flood in Orissa which washed away so many human lives there was no special celebration.

Vinoba doesn't like at all to be adored and, on the other hand, he doesn't pay much attention to visitors. Everybody who joins Vinoba's team is just an equal member sharing the same simplicities as others. And that's what I liked so much during these ten days' touring in the Koraput district. Nobody felt himself superior to the other. Each one had to do his duty without distinction between leader and team, always ready to help his neighbour walking beside. It was an “Army of Peace” on its march to “conquer” land.

I mention this particularly as some 12 years ago I was also marching 10 to 20 miles daily conquering land, but in a quite different way. I was wearing a grey uniform and was marked by a number. My leader told me everyday that I shouldn't think too much on myself and there are others who do it for me. And he used to tell me also when I had to use the gun hanging from my shoulder to shoot down my "enemies." Besides the road I saw burnt villages and homeless people. But I had no time to stop and help them as they were my "enemies" as said by my leader. It was war and no time for compassion.

How different I felt these days! I was again marching into a foreign land. But my comrade beside me didn't show an unhappy or hateful face. And there was no leader bawling out orders as each member of this army was still an individual led by his own conscience convinced that he was on the right path. When we reached a village people didn't disappear but they came gathering to welcome the "invaders" cheering Vinoba and Mahatma Gandhi.

Sometimes it was difficult to disperse the crowds to get a way free for Vinoba. Although they knew that the meeting will take place in a few hours, the villagers were waiting outside the house where Vinoba took shelter, for darshan.

I know only a few words of Hindi but actually there was no difficulty to understand Vinobaji's language. His gestures and practical demonstrations were understandable to everybody. For instance, he took once a young boy wearing a factory-made shirt of bad quality. "Look at that" and easily he tore the shirt into two pieces. "Why do you buy such cloth from the city if you are able to make your own clothing cheaper and of even better quality?" he

asked the assembly. Or he told them to stop smoking and planting tobacco while people are still hungry.

I thought people would leave the place if somebody would tell them such lectures. But just the contrary happened. The villagers were listening and remained seated even when heavy rain surprised the meeting. "Why should we go away" Vinoba said in such a case "if God gives His blessing?"

It is not at all new what Vinoba proclaims. But the way he talks and puts into practice his idea is revolutionary. His speeches are outpourings from heart to heart. How could it otherwise be possible that people, rich and poor, spontaneously are giving away their land to Bhoodan. Not only individuals, whole villages have given up private ownership of land.

A new life begins in these villages. There will be from now equal sharing of work and food. Khadi and cottage industry will be developed so that the village becomes as far as possible self-sufficient and independent from money economy.

Nobody would have believed in such a success of a single man when he started his pilgrimage four years ago with only a few disciples. Here, Andre Gide is right once more writing about "the secret of the small number" that the spiritual and moral power is significant for the success. The success lies not only in the gift of land but more in the change of heart and mind of the people. This is actually the revolution which is going on and lays the foundation-stone of a new society—not only for India but for the whole world.

Vinoba reminds us of what already 2000 years ago was preached but not yet realized—faith in truth and love. It is high time that the people, especially in the western world, follow the voice from the East.

(The writer is a German who was working in India as a Volunteer in the Service Civil International)

Vinoba and His Bhoodan Yagna

Hallam Tennyson

INDIA, the land of pilgrims, has added a new variety to its antique and exotic assortment: Vinoba Bhave, the leader and inspirer of the Land Gifts' Mission. Any morning at 4 o'clock you can see him and his companions trudging from village to village under a twilight sky. Behind lumbers a covered oxcart. And it's not until you look inside this cart that you realise that Vinoba is leading a new kind of pilgrimage. He himself is the very picture of a pre-historic Hindu sage. He is bent and bearded and carries a staff. He walks barefoot, swathed in coarse homespun. But the cart contains articles not usually indulged in by Indian ascetics. Among the bundles of bedding there are type-writers, stationery and a filing cabinet. For the cart is the mobile office of a Mission which, in two years, has collected no less than one million acres of land as free gifts for landless peasants. If it reaches its target of 50 million, the Mission will have achieved the largest peaceful revolution in history.

The Land Gifts' Mission started in 1951. That spring there was a meeting of rural workers in Hyderabad in an area where Communist agitators were murdering their landlords. Vinobaji never uses money, so he decided to walk to this meeting although it was some 300 miles away from where he lived. On the way, in every village through which he passed, he came face to face with the misery of the landless peasants. When he reached Hyderabad he went straight to a village where Communist violence

was daily expected and appealed to the landlords. "If you had four sons and a fifth was born," he said, "you would certainly give him a share of your land. Treat me as your fifth son and give me my share." Being Hindus the landlords' imaginations were touched. Land was given, and the Land Gifts' Mission was born. In his two months in Hyderabad Vinobaji received nearly 12,000 acres in trust for the landless. The Communists there have never regained their hold.

From Hyderabad Vinobaji was invited to Delhi to meet the Pandits of the Planning Commission. It took him two months to walk the 600 miles, but on the way he received 18,000 acres. From then on, the rest of India began to compete for his services. And like Felix the Cat, Vinobaji just keeps on walking.

What is Vinobaji's secret? When I first met him 6 years ago his name was known to very few. He lived in seclusion in a village in Central India. The day of my visit was a day of perishing heat, dust and monkeys. Vinobaji, undeterred by any of them sat spinning on the verandah of his mud hut. He talked of his experiment in self-sufficiency. He had a quick nervous smile and blinked at me over the top of his battered steel-rimmed spectacles. Then he returned to his spinning. His thin, frail body and his grey beard, made him look much older than his 52 years—a modern St. Simeon Stylites, reserved, recluse, austere. I was told that he had once been a scholar and had given up everything to lead the life of an obscure peasant. I was awe-struck but a little puzzled. I did not see how such a life, restricted by its bottle-neck of high principles, could ever affect the workaday world.

I ought to have known better. India honours one thing above all,—renunciation. Renunciation of worldly possessions, that ideal finds its echo in every Hindu heart. Even

industrial tycoons are still apt suddenly to throw up everything and retire to die in a mud hut by the Ganges. Vinobaji has reversed this process. At the age of 57, when most people think of retirement, Vinobaji has emerged from it.

It was Gandhiji who first demonstrated the powerful effect on his countrymen of renouncing wealth for the sake of human service rather than personal salvation. Vinobaji has trodden the same pathway into India's heart. He has no possessions beyond a spinning wheel and a few home spun clothes. Hundreds of people have offered him their cars so that he could move more quickly from village to village. They believed he would get more work done. But Vinobaji courteously refused such offers. The peasants can't afford cars and he knows better than to break the magic bond of sympathy that binds him to the peasants. Again Vinobaji suffers from ill-health. He has a chronic duodenal ulcer and is subject to dysentery. And this has made him old and frail before his time. Recently, when stricken with severe malaria, he refused to be treated with quinine since the peasants could not afford it. Is it any wonder that seeing this elderly saint slowly but surely ruining his health in their service, these same peasants should hold him in veneration?

But it is not only the poor who look on Vinobaji as a man of God. He touches the conscience of the wealthy as well. He approaches them in a spirit of loving conciliation. They are lucky, he says, for it is more blessed to give than to receive. And as the givers of land they are ennobled while the landless are merely the passive recipients of their rights. Not that Vinobaji is unduly tender to the susceptibilities of the rich. From a large landlord for instance he refuses anything less than 1/6th of his best property. He would rather have no land at all than land given merely as a

sop to public opinion. The gift must spring from a change of heart. And so, the landlords greet Vinobaji with garlands on his entry into a new village but they smile a little sheepishly at the prospect of being "fleeced."

To the Communist Vinobaji also speaks words of affection. He says, "If you would give up class hatred and truly work for the good of all, I would be the first to join you." And despite official Communist denunciations of his work, in some areas leading party members have contributed land. His approach is the same to all men, whatever their creed and conditions. An effort to reach the divine spark which he believes them to possess and then to make real to them the needs of their fellows in a language they can understand.

This ideal he has put quite literally into practice. Vinobaji has taught himself no less than 16 languages. At 46 he learned both Persian and Arabic so as to be able to converse more freely with his Muslim neighbours.

Vinobaji has acquired his strength through renunciation, much as India's ancient sages were supposed to acquire magical powers through their austerities. Vinobaji's magic is singleness of purpose and an iron will. There are many stories about his will-power. At the age of ten he is said to have sworn a vow of chastity from which he has never swerved. At the age of twenty when he joined Gandhiji's rural centre he took his certificates and diplomas—and being a brilliant scholar and mathematician he had many—and burned them one by one in the flame of an oil lamp, in spite of his mother's horrified protests. A few years later, at this same beloved mother's death he refused to attend her funeral, since the pyre would be lit by a Brahmin; and Vinobaji, although himself born an orthodox Brahmin, had come to disapprove of the caste system. When he joined

Gandhiji, the Mahatmaji told him to simplify life. Vinobaji took his words to heart. He vowed to wear no more than one garment at a time and to forego salt, the last remaining condiment which he allowed himself.

But with all his asceticism, Vinobaji has resisted pride of poverty—that subtlest temptation of the saints. He has never urged anyone else to follow his way of life. And he goes his own way with a striking serenity. To someone who asked him if his work would succeed, he replied, “Fire merely burns. It does not care whether anyone puts a pot on it, fills it with water and puts rice in it to make a meal. To burn is the limit of its duty.”

Out on the mission, of course, fellow pilgrims have to share his Spartan routine. At 3-30 a.m. twelve dry and commanding handclaps echo brusquely through the huts where the mission is sleeping—guest of a poor Muslim or untouchable as often as of a wealthy landlord. They pack up camp, then at 4 a.m. they assemble for prayers and silent spinning. In half an hour they set off on foot for their next stopping place. When day breaks they halt for a roadside breakfast, vegetarian and spare like all their meals. A crowd gathers, and while he eats Vinobaji chats with the people and listens to their problems. By 10 a.m. the party has reached the village where it will stay till next morning. Vinobaji settles under a tree to spin and summons the local landlords.

If they seem apathetic, he shakes a gentle, skinny forefinger at them and reminds them of the horror and violence that will sweep the country unless the peasants get their rights. In the evening a meeting takes place in a shed specially decorated with flowers and votive lamps. It starts with prayers. Then the landlords are invited to declare how much land they are ready to give. Perhaps there is not enough offered to meet the needs of all the landless. If so

Vinobaji asks the landless themselves to choose the most deserving, and at the same time encourages the landlords to make their donations bigger. At one place an Untouchable who owned only 1/5th of an acre offered his tiny plot, since he had just got a job in a nearby factory. Vinobaji gravely took the gift-deed from him, then endorsed it to the effect that since he belonged to the class to whom land should be given, his plot should be returned to him forthwith.

Scenes like that arouse an atmosphere of almost evangelical fervour. People start trying to outdo each other in generosity. But Vinobaji is careful to canalise the flood of emotion. He sits by as level-headed as ever ; garlanded like an emaciated and reluctant Caesar. Then he sets up a village committee to supervise the cultivation of the distributed land and to obtain seeds and implements from the Government officials. From those receiving land he extracts a pledge that they will not resell for ten years. By 8 p.m. the meeting is usually over, and an hour later the pilgrim retires to sleep. They have to be on the move again at 3-30 the next morning. Vinobaji shuns publicity. He will almost certainly tick me off for talking about him like this. He himself has refused to be interviewed on the air. He has said that if Gandhiji had not been assassinated he would never have dared to come out of his retirement. Yet he is no mere imitator of Gandhiji. In India where saints and specially dead saints—exercise an enormous, even a paralysing influence on people's minds, one might have expected Vinobaji to disguise himself in the mantle which others claim to have fallen on his shoulders. He does not. He rarely speaks of Gandhiji in public. He has his own dignity, emphasis and methods. Like a candle, lit at a neighbouring flame, he now burns with a steady and separate light.

In contrast to most ascetics too Vinobaji believes in the future and in human kind. He once said, "People call this an age of sin and degradation, yet how can that be? The Buddha is supposed to have lived in a time freer from sin than our own. Yet someone as great as he had to pay a heap of gold for nothing but a small parcel of land; while I, mere humble devotee of God, have been entrusted with thousands of acres as free gifts."

Vinobaji is the embodiment of India. In spite of his wide culture and learning Westerners might find him less easy to approach than Gandhiji. When first I met him I thought him reserved, almost remote. When he spoke, his simple, unsophisticated language, suited to an audience of illiterate peasants, fell oddly on the jaded ears of Europe. Yet most great spirits have shaped their message to conditions no less restricted. My last glimpse of Vinobaji was the same as my first. He was squatting outside his mud hut, bent like a scholar over his spindle. A group of peasants crouched round him expecting guidance and help. He was talking to them in his quite courteous way. And I thought, it will be the same to-morrow and the day after and the day after that until he dies. And there was something about the image that this thought conjured up, something in the enormous tranquility of his patience and his faith, which told me that Vinobaji's message was not limited to the country in which it was uttered. The twentieth century may be rich in jet aeroplanes, but it is pretty poor in saints. We need to remember that what we call 'progress' is nothing if it leads to no corresponding inner change, and Vinobaji gives us this reminder in the one way which has power to move and impress by the example of a life and character utterly dedicated to the service of his fellows and the God he believes to be revealed in them.

(A Talk on the B. B. C. London in April 1953)

What I felt in Bhoodan Yatra

Leon Bensimon

SINCE words are a limited form of expression, I must admit that this article will be naturally incomplete in summing up my feelings after a brief experience in the Bhoodan Yatra with Vinobaji for about six weeks from Chandil to Giridi in Bihar. What we really feel in the great depth of our soul cannot be reproduced authentically in words. So I venture only to indicate some of the sentiments and feelings of a Westerner like me, engaged now in the study of Indian life and by that way in a humanitarian work. This article is evidently more emotional than intellectual.

The morning of the 9th March, 1953, at Chandil (Bihar) was the day of the opening of the annual conference of the Sarvodaya Samaj (International Brotherhood of Gandhiji) and there was an inspiring atmosphere with Vinobaji, Rajendra Babu and 2,000 Sevaks. Hundreds of charkhas were humming their song of hope and love. On the early morning of the 12th March Vinoba starts again. Some one hundred Sevaks follow him in his march.

At one place a boy of 15 years spent one month in receiving Bhoodan of one hundred acres for the landless in his village and a younger boy also followed his way.

How can one describe this Vinoba, this thin man walking and walking on miles of distance? His steps are short but so quick that we feel nervous sometimes if he would stumble on a stone. He never stops on the way even for offerings. It seems as if he is not free to do what he wants, for a mysterious fire burning within is goading him onwards. One day he made us all including young men and

girls run behind him. He is now almost sixty years and his body seems to be as light as that of a Yogi. He is full of good humour and I saw him playing with a three-year little girl.

It is not easy to describe the high hopes and faith aroused among the people as soon as Vinobaji arrives in a village or a town. The mass enthusiasm of the peasants and workers is tremendous.

The silent departure of the party every morning headed by Vinoba Bhawe with his thin legs but made of steel walking brisk and fast with the spirit goading him to move on is unforgettable.

When the solemn and silent moment comes for the peasants to sign their gift-deeds it looks that a certain moral force is generated in the whole world with the sure possibility of its effect early or late, near or far.

A Harijan woman knows not to sign her name and gently puts her thumb-impression on the gift-deed. The so-called illiterate too has here to offer a message of love to the intellectuals whose hearts have dried up!

Vinobaji's daily speeches are not set and pre-planned but they are inspired by the local environments and the problems peculiar to each place he visits.

At Purulia several ladies one after another came forward to throw off their jewellery, the symbols of vanity of worldly things. By freeing themselves from these shackles of bondage they deliver the message for others about the real wealth that is obtained through sacrifice.

And just think of a Minister who leaves his office, and goes walking across the province in order to collect land, from house to house and from farm to farm.

A peasant, very sick, lies stretched out on his bed whom two American ladies and myself visited; and he offers us one acre each out of his 10 acres. He has seven children and takes us as additional members of his family.

Students and others who understand the mission of the Apostle of Bhoodan come forward to serve the cause or give land. Various songs on the mission are composed and sung by the enthusiastic youths. A whole village offers its land to Vinoba. Some Harijan peasants donate half of their land (in some *bighas*) and also invite the party to share their simple evening meal.

It looks almost a dream to me particularly an European to witness a village giving away the whole of its land as gift. It is hardly possible to restrain one's emotion at this sight. How I felt before the Harijans (untouchables) who having given away half of their land invited us to share surplus dinner also!

At the last moment when I left Vinobaji at Giridi, on some pilgrimage, he said in French with a lovely smile: "*Au Revoir*" meaning "Good-bye."

This experience makes me recall what a former British Minister said recently somewhere in South India addressing constructive workers:

"Now I am here after having a long fight to come here. I want to see whether work has been done or merely talked about. Now it seems to me that what you are doing and what you are going to do is in some respects the most important work in the world. I think, perhaps, it is not easy for you to appreciate quite how important it is. You are so near to it that perhaps you do not see in the proper perspective.

“We are very anxious in Europe to find out whether India can transform her society, her present population, backward way of life, with more advanced methods without having to resort to the coercive methods which have been adopted in other countries.

“There is obviously a very great gap between the urban population of India, especially some of them, and the peasantry of India. The less that gap is narrowed the greater the civilization. You have certain advantages which we do not have. And the most important one is that you started later than we did. So you can benefit by all the mistakes we made. And no one can say that we have not made many. Also the Soviet Union has made many mistakes. So also China is inclined to make mistakes. So India can show us the way. What she has to do is to prove them that free men and women by the use of free institutions can raise the material standard of life and maintain the essential virtues.”

(The writer is from France, who spent three years in India as a Volunteer in the S. C. I.)

The World Bhoodan Movement

Rev. R. R. Keithahn

THE rural-based life and society is essential to creative living. "Feet-on-the-soil" living will alone assure the Good Society. The natural togetherness, face-to-face living of the village is a basic condition for the development of the man, the creative home, the community school, the co-operative economy, the true community and dynamic religion.

There is something profound for developing personality as one wrestles with the Creator in potential Nature for the feeding, clothing and housing of man. Out in God's world it is natural to 'lift one's eyes unto the hills' and ask, yes, and answer the profound questions of mankind. The village home gives the family meaningful vocation for growing lives, so that each member has its important place in a co-operating fellowship, the basis for integrated living. The rural environment has always stimulated co-operative living of the highest type. Democratic society naturally takes some definite form in rural areas. There is much to be said for the statement that 'the great historical and living religions have been essentially rural religions.'

From an Industrial to a Welfare Society Capitalistic industrialism has failed miserably to satisfy the needs of a co-operating and creative world community. The potential machine which has been so widely used for exploitation and destruction, neutral but dedicated science which has all too often been the servant of demonic forces, must now be taken to the great and needy rural areas of mankind—must be welded into a great pattern of true and selfless service for all.

It is tragic that science, the machine and ruthless man have brought the world to the brink of destruction—that the villager, especially the eastern and African villager, has been the victim of this heartless exploitation while the good religious man, the middle classman, all too often the village man, has permitted himself to be a tool in such vicious processes.

As never before we must integrate the Religion of Truth, and for us that is at least potentially the religion of the Carpenter of Nazareth and the Living Christ, into the very web of daily living. Work must become worship, plowing a prayer, harvesting a hymn of gratitude. There should go out from our midst a message to the Church that will be a message of Hope, a call to pilgrimage, for the Rural Church.

We must grapple with the land problem—is it not the problem number one of this Eastern world? Some believe that the most significant religious movement of this Day is directed towards this baffling problem—the Bhoodan Movement of Acharya Vinoba: an attempt at the creating of “the right atmosphere” in which such a difficult problem may be solved. We must give our constructive reply to this movement. Here is an effort to give man a substantial basis for the “trusteeship” of the soil, and I believe, for all Natural Resources. It has revolutionary implications for all the world. In fact, I am convinced we cannot get on with the real job of building world community until we begin working at this strategic problem. When we relate all villagers to the soil we begin the task of foundation construction of world society. And I need not remind of the tremendous implications of this for the society. And this has further implications for the village church. Ours are largely landless agricultural labourers in the village church. Can we ever have a real rural church unless it is built on the

soil? Can we ever have "self-sufficient" churches unless its members possess land?

Bhoodan insists on "trusteeship" of the soil. Vinobaji maintains that only in such an atmosphere can we have an adequate development of the individual and the true pattern of co-operation. As Christians we are deeply concerned with "stewardship", man and the co-operative pattern. Are we going to relate ourselves vitally to this movement or are we going to continue in our castles of indifference, complacency and cheap intellectual criticism?

The Day of Charity must go; the Day of Justice is with us. There will always be a sharing of God's blessings in times of crisis. The world economy must be based upon justice. Christians cannot tolerate as a permanent situation the fact of 1,000 people living on a square mile of land in Travancore, but ten on a square mile in Australia with colour, racial and economic curtains as rigid as iron curtains. Someone has recently reminded mankind that most of us today live on stolen property. It is high time that we have a world "Bhoodan Movement"—a placing of the enormous natural resources of the world into a trusteeship for the welfare of all "without distinction of caste, class or creed."

Vinoba's Correct Approach

Leon Hirsch

The writer, an American graduate in philosophy and M. B. A. has been in India under the Research Fellowship of Ford Foundation. Before returning to U. S. A. he wanted to study Bhoodan movement. He was with Vinobaji's yatra for a few days and here is his spontaneous reaction to what he saw and heard about Vinobaji's non-violent technique of mass action written specially for 'Sarvodaya'.

RECENTLY I walked, ate, and slept with Vinoba and a group of about twenty Bhoodan workers for several days. In this short time, even I, not an Indian, but an American student of economics, could see the tremendous merit of Bhavé's way.

I am not "against" development. Far from it. I could not be called a Gandhian. Why then am I so enthused about Vinoba and the way he has pointed out?

You cannot speak Telugu to a Punjabi and expect him to understand, at least not until he learns the language. In a similar way, you must speak to villagers in terms that they understand. Instead of seeking to impose solutions from above, Vinoba approaches the villagers in familiar ways; he talks to them so that they understand him. Vinoba does not try to put into effect a prearranged solution to "uplift the masses". He seeks to prepare them so that they themselves can arrange their own lives to their best benefits. The seeds for a full and meaningful life are there in India's half-million villages. Vinoba is readying the ground so that these seeds might grow and bear fruit.

Vinoba feels that laws, without a change in people's hearts are not very effective. He cites the fact that though there is a law forbidding discrimination against Harijans, still it continues. We in America have this same difficulty with regard to giving the Negro his equal rights. Vinobaji's approach is to first cause a revolution in people's hearts, and then concern himself about legislation. Similarly you cannot create full meaningful lives by plans and programs, without first preparing the groundwork through direct sympathetic contact with the villagers—and this is Vinoba's way.

The cornerstone of Vinoba's whole program is flexibility. Just as he inspires the village folk, they inspire him. This mutual process is what is so outstanding about his approach. The evolution of Bhoodan into Gramdan, and all the other "dans" has been a natural one. Although Vinoba firmly believes in village co-operation, he does not prescribe the particular structure of this co-operation, but leaves this to the villages. Here is his great strength.

I do not feel that Vinoba is "against" industrialization. He himself has stated this many times. Once the groundwork is laid enabling villagers to decide for themselves how they hope to realize full lives, then they can choose how much and what forms of industrialization they find most suitable to their needs as they see them. So Vinoba is not "against" anything. He is for helping people realize themselves in ways that they think are best.

Some say that although they sympathize with Vinoba, the ideas of appealing directly to villagers is unworkable and Utopian. But couldn't this have been said about that earlier manifestation of Indian genius, Gandhi's non-violent approach to independence?

Six Months of Bhoodan Yatra

Donald B. Groom

The writer is a well-known British Quaker who has been serving India as a Gandhian constructive worker through the Ashram in Rasulia (M. P.) during the last 15 years. After walking for about six months on Bhoodan yatra covering 1,400 miles (in M. P.) he recently spent two weeks with Vinobaji in Tanjore district. He has recently left for England to spread the message of Bhoodan with special reference to world problems.

I HAVE travelled on foot for over 1,500 miles and visited about 400 villages. Time goes slowly—everyday brings new experiences and every day a new world is opened before me. Where we are going to sleep, what and where we are going to eat are unknown factors daily. But although we depend entirely on the village hospitality there is never any doubt that there will be place to sleep, and adequate provision within the means of the village for our bodily needs. What success we are receiving is no doubt a question on the readers' minds; I can't make a generalisation, but I would like to describe a few incidents.

In one village 35 small cultivators gave a total of 125 acres, one donor giving five out of his ten acres. In one small town over 200 Harijans filled in Sampattidan forms pledging a portion of their small income for the next five years. One participant in a special land collection effort in the Narsingpur district collected over 500 acres in five days. In Sagar district village after village sent us away without a single acre, and we seriously considered whether we should refuse to take food if no land were received. We later

discovered that in that area there had been a definite anti-Bhoodan movement under the false impression that Vinoba Bhave was making anti-Ramayana statements.

We do not measure the success of the tour by the amount of land we receive, as our main aim is to pass on the message of Bhoodan to as many people as possible. I participate fully in this task and find that people all over are very interested in the fact that an Englishman is one of the Bhoodan 'batch'. It seems to them that I am making a great sacrifice, but that is not true; I am sharing in a great movement and the experience is invaluable. If anyone is making a sacrifice it is.....

When I started on the walk I was fully convinced of the need for the movement in India, and indeed in the world, but I was not sure that the organisation was sufficient to carry forward such a movement and fulfil its aims. Now, after six months, I am more than ever convinced of the importance of the movement and have a feeling that in spite of all weaknesses it will achieve its objective. I think that Vinoba Bhave is giving an inspired message, not occasionally, but daily, and it is of utmost importance that people in India and abroad should read and understand the real significance of this message. I feel sure that Friends will agree that Vinoba is giving the true Quaker message for this day and generation.

'The Friendly Way'

A Revolution in True Sense

David Graham and Ian Dixon

WE joined Vinobaji and his group at Vanjinagaram at 4 p.m. on January 7, and were bade welcome by the Bhoodan workers. Among them were Gladys Owen, an English lady from the Quaker Centre at Delhi, and a young American Quaker, Louise Evans, who had come to India on a grant from the Fulbright College. She was studying sociology and had worked in Mexico assisting in rehabilitation work.

All Vinobaji's meetings are called 'Prayer Meetings'. We were just in time for the 5 p.m. prayer. This was to be held in the village square.

We took our place with the assembled villagers before the bench where Vinobaji was to sit. We noted that Vinobaji had no objection to the incorporation of modern scientific equipment in his retinue.

There were two loudspeakers, two mikes (one for the interpreter) and a tape recorder. All this equipment is transported by jeeps, usually about three are present. Luggage is also transported in the jeeps.

The chatter and hum of the congregation ceased. At 5 p.m. precisely, Vinobaji appeared. We had our first view of this man of whom the whole world is aware. He made his way to the low bench, a frail man wearing dark spectacles and a shawl over his head to protect him from the still hot sun.

As he passed by, we glanced at the faces of the audience. We realised then that to them Vinobaji was no

'man', he was the messenger of God who had come to prevent them from living the lives of beggars.

He is their messenger of hope—to them he is a Saint. In their eyes were reflected their hopes as they folded their hands in fervent salutation. Some looked awed, even frightened.

As he walks on his mission an old man at work in the field touched his companion on the shoulder, "Look Gandhiji is approaching."

His compatriot replies, "Refresh your memory, old man. Gandhi has been dead many a year."

The old man responds, "My son, Gandhiji never died, walking there is his spirit. Gandhi still lives!"

We have no doubt that many in Vinoba's audience have similar thoughts about him.

Quietly he took his place on the bench beside the interpreter. Vinobaji speaks 18 languages, amongst them Tamil, the tongue of Tamilnad, the State where he is touring. But Vinobaji speaks "high Tamil" not the dialect, so he addresses them in Hindi, and it is interpreted.

His voice is quiet, but it has great spirit and strength. At the beginning he is extremely passive. After half an hour, he shows some emotion and becomes extremely eloquent and fluent. Although we could follow nothing of his speech, we were fascinated by his hand gestures.

In every respect he is non-violent, yet he exudes positive power. His gesticulations are urgent and distinct—full of energy. It is difficult to put into writing the atmosphere which surrounds him.

He spoke for one hour. After his speech we sat with him for some time. We told him of our work at "Anandavan" and of the health of Mr. Amte.

What struck us plain was his quietness, his simplicity. He is humble, he does no more than to ask for the love of all people. But the one thing which Vinobaji does not desire is to be 'sanctified'. We wished him "namasthe" and left.

Everyone is up at 3-30 a.m. for communal prayers. When we reached his room, Vinobaji was reading (we find this is so every morning) and the book is generally a religious one. He has read most of the religious scriptures. He learned Arabic especially to read the *Koran* in the original.

We sat with the others cross-legged on the floor. The lanterns were dimmed, the chant started—it continues for about twenty minutes. Whether or not one is "religious" in the narrow sense of the word is unimportant. At that hour of the morning it is quiet and peaceful, it is good to sit quietly, we feel that it is of great benefit.

At 5-45 a.m., Vinobaji is on his way. The next village where we are to stop and make camp is Kottampatti, seven miles away. He sets off at a cracking pace and hardly falters for the full distance.

We are young, Vinobaji is old—but we wouldn't like to challenge him to a walking race—this frail old man!

The only halt is when he takes his curds and buttermilk in the early morning after the commencement of the walk. He can take only non-solids because he has a stomach ulcer.

In every village through which we passed, people had erected arches with "Welcome" on them. Streamers had been strung from tree to tree alongside the road. Even before we reached a village people would be waiting by the roadside to welcome us.

The number of escorts were about 25, but the group varied in size from scores to hundreds. As we approached a village the children would sing or drums would beat. The song would be about Vinobaji and how he is doing work of God, how he goes on foot from village to village bringing hope and joy.

The jeeps have arrived before us and people have prepared the sleeping quarters for the night, the loudspeakers have been prepared. All the food and the petrol for the jeeps are found by the villagers.

Previously this was paid for by the Gandhi Nidhi Fund. But Bhoodan has broken all ties with outside organisations. It is dependent entirely upon the people.

After the 'crusade' which varies from five to ten miles all are ready for the breakfast. The food is always excellent—there is no doubt that the people give of their very best.

After breakfast, time is free. But we, the two Englishmen and the young man from Japan are never free of the curiosity of the village folk. We have only to stand around a few moments for a large crowd to gather. They want to know about us.

We told where we came from and why, then we invited questions. Fast and furiously they came. We felt that here was a good opportunity for us all to get to know each

other. What a variety of questions! "Is there caste system in England?" "Do you need Bhoodan in England?" Their thirst for knowledge was insatiable.

We had to bring the meeting to a close in order to hear Vinobaji's speech at 5 p.m.

We listened to Vinobaji's speech, one of his secretaries interpreted for us. His illustrations and analogies are profound and simple, they go straight to the heart. He is not an intellectual who makes complexities. He tells how things should be and why they are not.

"Unhappiness is not natural, man has created unhappiness." There can be no contradiction to his talks—he speaks pure and simple truth. He rejects politicians and Governments, he rejects might and violence, he rejects pomp and ceremony.

For his Bhoodan—land gift—he does no more than to ask those who have to give to those who have not. "Take me in as a member of your family, let the whole village become one family."

As we walk with Vinobaji and his Bhoodan workers we share their happiness. Wherever they go they carry with them the spirit of brotherhood—the message of a new life to be.

We feel that we are fortunate to be here in India witnessing a miracle, a miracle which has happened almost overnight. But we must not forget that Vinobaji is building on the foundation that Gandhiji laid. Vinobaji is taking the philosophy of Gandhiji one step further, a step no doubt which Gandhi himself would have taken had he lived.

A revolution is occurring, but this is a revolution in the true sense—a change of heart—not just a change of government. To change the hearts of people will take longer than to merely to replace administrators, but slowly it will succeed. Land-owners are donating land; many workers are giving a proportion of their income to those who through no fault of their own, are unable to earn a living. Bhoodan workers are dedicating their lives.

Bhoodan is like a snowball starting to roll from a mountain top. It will gather more snow until it becomes a roaring avalanche. Bhoodan must cross the borders of India—in Sarvodaya lies new hope for the world.

“Sunday Standard” March 17, 1957.

Mrs. Chester Bowles' Interview

Damodardas Mundada

MRS. CHESTER BOWLES, friend of India, and one of the signatories to the '*Kup Dan yagna*' (Well Fund Mission) in England and America called upon Vinobaji the other day at a small village—Koradacheri—in Tanjore District.

Long before her arrival, she had already written to him about her proposed visit. She had seen him suffering from throat trouble when she met him last in Utkal. "Have you any sore throat now?" was therefore the first question she asked after they greeted each other.

Thanking her for the kind query, Vinobaji offered her a seat to his right. "I am hard of hearing" said he pointing to his left ear.

"I am too: Do you hear me now?" asked Mrs. Bowles, taking the provided seat.

And as he nodded the talk proceeded. Mrs. Bowles apologised for her husband's inability to come and see him in the South. "He is so glad to see your programme progressing, especially the Gramdan side of it" she added.

She then referred to the Community Project villages which she had visited last time. "Are these villages making any progress, Vinobaji?" she asked.

"They are progressing in their own way" he replied; "but they can't make any progress until the problem of poverty is solved. Mr. Dey told me how the poor in the villages were unable to avail of any substantial help from the scheme, and how it were the more able alone who

extracted it. Mr. Dey made no secret of his experience and confessed that they were not able to reach the poorest. That is their difficulty. They are working from above."

"Did you say that to Mr. Dey?"

"Yes. And he agreed with my views."

"What is your solution, Vinobaji?"

"My solution obviously is Gramdan."

"Certainly, and then alone will the Development programme progress in the right direction."

"Yes. It is so!" And narrating his experience in Madura District, Vinobaji pointed out how the Development officers in the district were interested in the Gramdan Movement.

Mr. Harris, who accompanied Mrs. Bowles as her Secretary, wanted to know from Vinobaji if the idea of Bhoodan could be related to countries outside India for bridging the gulf between the rich and the poor.

"I have said many a time that Bhoodan is not limited to any particular area. It is related to world problems and can be applied according to the circumstances. Did I not refer to Japan and Australia and plead that Australia should be ready to welcome the Japanese? It is my firm conviction that Land is the Lord's and does not belong to any individual or nation. It belongs to humanity at large."

"And what about Sampathidan?"

"It is not so important, because after all money has no real value. It is only a conception. You may have any money in your pocket but it may prove valueless if it failed

to fetch any article of use in return. Your money has some value because I want to sell my produce for one reason or other. But it is not so with land. It is an essential means of production. It has its own intrinsic, absolute value."

"But" intervened Mrs. Bowles "while some countries are rich in raw materials and other natural resources, others are comparatively very poor. May the principle of free exchange be applied there?"

Vinoba: "Of course! There must be free exchange of raw materials and natural resources. Articles of primary necessities, however, should be manufactured locally in the village itself. The question of exchange should arise for the secondary needs only."

Mr. Harris referred to the co-operative movement in China and Israel and wanted to know if India had any lesson to learn from such countries.

Appreciating these efforts and expressing his readiness to accept the good points therein, such as the Japanese method of paddy cultivation etc., Vinobaji pointed out how every country had its own habits and conventions and so far as co-operation was concerned, India may not accept these in the same form. "There may be differences in conditions in Israel and those in India and you will have to take all these factors into consideration."

"But the India Government is proposing to start a lakh of producers' co-operatives in this country and we would like to know if you approve the proposal?"

"Without Gramdan, the scheme will neither be feasible nor useful. It will prove helpful only on the basis of Gramdan."

At this Mrs. Bowles wanted to know if there was any administrative change in the Gramdan villages, after the Gramdan was effected and if so, what was its nature.

Said Vinobaji, "Gramdan meant a change in the very psychology of the people which can transform the whole life to suit the new context. Today X requires money for the marriage celebration of Y and borrows it from Z. But in a Gramdan village there will be no difficulty whatsoever, because the marriage there is a community affair and the question of raising a personal loan would not arise at all."

Mrs. Bowles, who happened to meet Sri Cherian Thomas of the All India Pad Yatra, at New Delhi, informed Vinobaji how Sri Cherian was dreaming of the day when the Nation may meet to make a declaration of the liquidation of personal proprietorship in land.

At this, Mrs. Bowles was informed how the beginning was already made on Taluka basis and how the Tirumangalam Taluka had pledged on the eve of the Independence Day to offer Taluka Dan within a period of three months. She was also greatly impressed with the form of the pledge which the representatives of the Taluka took on the occasion.

And Sri Aryanayakamji who had just returned from Sevagram brought the news as to how Maharashtra has already stolen an advance in Firkadan by donating 52 villages in Kolhapur District in Azra Mahal. In spite of the fact that this had happened a week earlier, the news had only just appeared in a Bombay Marathi daily, and this was read out to Vinobaji. At this, the visitors expressed their surprise and said that if even ten villages would surrender their ownership in this way in America, the whole nation would wonder at the miracle, and the news would appear on the front page with full page headlines.

Pointing to another news item in the same paper, appearing in two columns bold type head lines, regarding the arrest of a man alleged to have been involved in some murder case, Vinobaji said how even this news of Firkadan would have appeared in big bold type and full page head lines had it taken place through violent means, for then it would have been considered as a revolution! Evidently, the visitors were surprised at the apathy of the press in educating the public in this great and unique revolutionary process of voluntary liquidation of ownership. Vinobaji, however, did not seem to depend at all on these modern methods of publicity, for, according to him, revolutions worked silently in their own way and the world knew them only after their accomplishment.

Mrs. Bowles then informed Vinobaji, how the Negro leader Mr. King, who successfully fought for the Negroes' right of travelling in the American buses, on non-segregation basis, was coming to India to meet him and walk with him during his trek. "As a lawyer" Mr. Harris pointed out "I must confess that the movement was taken up by the 'Ministers' preaching in church and not by the lawyers practising in the courts."

"That is a very good news" exclaimed Vinobaji.

"It is the first spark of light, as such a thing had never happened in America before" exclaimed Mrs. Bowles. "Now they have begun to use the buses on non-segregation basis." Mrs. Bowles wanted to know, if these sparks appearing all over the world including South Africa and America be combined and how. "God will do that through individuals like you" assured Vinobaji. "That would be part of your mission of carrying good news from here to there and from there to here."

The visitors wanted to know the reason why the educated people felt shy of responding to Bhoodan.

"It is very strange indeed that the intellectual class does not know how to avail of this great awakening," Mrs. Bowles expressed her feelings. "But the children will show them the path" she added. Obviously she was referring to the unanimous vote of the children in the prayer meeting, who, on being asked by Vinobaji about their views on Gramdan had raised their hands to manifest their support to the proposal. (The prayer meeting was going on when Mrs. Bowles arrived and she had joined the meeting before she had talked to Vinobaji. She was also greatly impressed by the five minutes' silence at the end of the meeting, especially by the children quietly participating in it.) Referring to the conditions in her own country and in other countries also, Mrs. Bowles pointed out how the people there followed those leaders who made only speeches. "But Bhoodan has indeed now created a new dimension in the political life!" she added.

Referring again to the Negro Movement in America Mrs. Bowles asked, "What place do you see, Vinobaji, for that kind of Satyagraha in the present democratic set-up of India?"

Vinobaji: "The Satyagraha of the old type which we practised in the days of Gandhiji was rather of a negative type. 'Quit India' he said to the British. This was but natural in the circumstances. But now, after Swaraj and when so-called Democracy is functioning, the Satyagraha should be of a positive and constructive type. I am hoping that Gramdan will show the way to that sort of Satyagraha. But the people will slowly know what is conversion and what is compulsion and they will soon realise that there was

no necessity for compulsion. In a Democratic country the Satyagraha should be a positive and an elevating force. We can't say mend or end. We will have to mend only and there can be no question of ending. The old experience we have with us, and the new method of positive Satyagraha will emerge out of it. Our negative Satyagraha was able to secure freedom for us, but it has not been able to generate positive and effective non-violent force. People do not yet feel that there is a positive force such as love before which all kinds of evil will melt away. That kind of conviction is wanting. We have to cultivate that faith and conviction in the potency of Love and non-violence."

Mrs. Bowles wanted some more elucidation on the form of Satyagraha. "To fight an unjust Legislation", said Vinobaji, "Our action should not be negative, i.e., there should not be want of love. The force of action should be positive love. That I do not hate you is not enough. I must love you also, notwithstanding your faults, because I am also not faultless. I must be ever ready to love you. That will create a positive force. It exists in every heart and requires but to be manifested. From times immemorial, we had spent our time, energy and resources to develop the power of violence. It won't even take as much time to develop non-violence."

"How could the Scientists who were responsible for the various inventions, prevent the abuse of their discoveries?"

"They can certainly resist non-violently the use of their discoveries for violent actions" was the prompt remedy prescribed.

"What part were the landless to play in this Bhoodan?" was the next question,

“The landless people should know that their power to work is the greatest power in the world. They should therefore come forward to offer Shramdan i.e., labour gifts. They will thus create a moral force. They should not be under the impression that they are only to receive. They are able to give and they should do so in the form of labour and that too through love.”

Last but not least, Mrs. Bowles wanted to know if the United Nations Organisation could be the agency through which the ideas of Bhoodan could work on the international plane.

“I wish it could,” replied Vinobaji. “But I am not very optimistic about this organisation of the United Nations. No doubt they sit round the table but still they do not trust one another. They meet each other with suspicion.”

And as the talk concluded and Vinobaji thanked them for their visit, Mrs. Bowles exclaimed, “It is so charming to hear you speak English!”



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